Lesson 4 — One Small Thing, Many Times

Level: A2+ (fourth step)

Theme: Web design, online learning and a small shop

Time: 6 sessions, 45–55 minutes each

Skills: Listening → Reading → Vocabulary → Grammar → Comprehension → Speaking → Writing

New in this lesson: the present perfect with for, since, never, already and yet, the short forms of have and has, a longer passage of 400 words, and one new question type: the purpose of the whole passage

01 · Passage — One Small Thing, Many Times

> How to do the listening. The same rule as every lesson so far: the student listens twice with no text, then reads. Audio files: `01-passage.mp3` first, then the other parts in order. Part `05-have-has-forms.mp3` is new — the short forms of have and has.

1.1 Before listening (2 minutes, Arabic is fine here)

1. What have you learned without a teacher?
2. How long have you studied English?
3. Is there something you started and have not finished yet?

1.4 Now read the passage

Passage: One Small Thing, Many Times (400 words)

Lina is twenty-four. She lives in Gaza, and she has studied information technology at her college for three years. She has also done something her teachers never asked for: she has taught herself web design.

[A] It started two years ago, with a free course on the internet. The course has more than forty lessons, and Lina has finished thirty-eight of them. She has never met her teacher. He lives in another country, and she has only seen his hands, moving on a keyboard, in short videos.

The connection in her building is slow, so she has learned to work in a careful way. She downloads a lesson at night, when the internet is quieter. She watches it in the morning, with no connection at all. She has lost her work many times, and now she saves every few minutes.

[B] Her uncle has a small shop near the market. He has sold the same things for twenty years — bags, shoes, school things — and he has always sold them in the same way. People come to the shop, or they telephone him.

In March, Lina built a website for the shop. It is a simple one: four pages, some photographs, the prices, and a button that opens a message to her uncle's phone. She published it on a free service, because the shop has no money for anything else. It took her eleven days.

[C] Since March, the shop has had customers from three other cities. They have never seen the shop, and they will probably never see it. They found the website, they looked at the prices, and they sent a message. Two of them have ordered from the shop more than once.

Her uncle has not learned to use a computer, and he does not want to. He has never used email. But he has asked Lina for two new pages, and he has started to say "my website" when he talks to his friends.

[D] Lina has not finished the course yet. Two lessons are left, and they are the hardest ones. She has already decided what she will build after them: an account system, so that a customer can see what he has ordered before.

She says the same thing to every student who asks her how to begin. "I have not done anything big," she says. "I have done one small thing, many times, for two years".

1.5 Read aloud

Read the passage aloud once and record it. Compare it with your Lesson 3 recording: is the voice steadier now?

02 · Listening questions

1.2 Listening — first time (no text)

L1. Who is the story about, and what has she taught herself?

L2. How long has she studied at her college?

L3. What did she build in March, and who for?

L4. Has she finished the course?

1.3 Listening — second time (no text)

Write four verbs in the present perfect that you heard (has or have + the past participle). Then write one word you heard but did not understand.

03 · Vocabulary and Lesson 2 recall

2.1 Key words

#	WORD	TYPE	SIMPLE MEANING	ARABIC	EXAMPLE
1	website	noun	a group of pages on the internet	موقع إلكتروني	Lina built a website for the shop.
2	page	noun	one screen of a website	صفحة	The site has four pages.
3	online	adjective	on the internet; connected	على الإنترنت	She took a free online course.
4	course	noun	a set of lessons on one subject	دورة	The course has more than forty lessons.
5	publish	verb	to put something on the internet for everyone	ينشر	She published it on a free service.
6	customer	noun	a person who buys something	زبون	The shop has had customers from other cities.
7	price	noun	how much money something costs	سعر	They looked at the prices.
8	connection	noun	the link between your machine and the internet	اتصال	The connection in her building is slow.
9	button	noun	the thing you press on a screen	زر	A button opens a message to his phone.
10	account	noun	your own name and password on a website	حساب	She will build an account system.
11	password	noun	the secret word that opens your account	كلمة المرور	Never give anyone your password.
12	update	verb	to make something newer	يحدّث	He has asked her to update the prices.
13	free	adjective	costing no money	مجاني	It started with a free course.
14	order	verb	to ask a shop to send you something	يطلب	A customer can see what he has ordered.

2.2 Synonyms and opposites

WORD	SYNONYM	OPPOSITE
free	costing nothing	expensive
online	on the internet	offline
publish	put it online	hide / keep private

WORD	SYNONYM	OPPOSITE
customer	buyer	seller / shopkeeper
hardest	most difficult	easiest
quiet	with little noise	busy / noisy
begin	start	finish / end
many	a lot of	few

2.3 Expressions to learn

EXPRESSION	WHAT IT REALLY MEANS
teach yourself	learn something with no teacher
step by step	one small part at a time
for two years	a length of time, from then until now
since March	a point in time, from then until now
not … yet	it has not happened, but it probably will
many times	again and again
he has started to say	he did not say it before, and now he does

2.4 Vocabulary practice

A. Write the opposite:

1. free → _____
2. online → _____
3. publish → _____
4. customer → _____
5. begin → _____

B. Which word is different? Say why:

1. website — page — link — market
2. customer — price — shop — password
3. published — built — found — free

C. Say it in your own words:

1. What is a website?
2. What does publish mean?

04 · Grammar — the present perfect

Come back to: the past continuous

Lesson 3 taught it. Two lines to remind you:

I / HE / SHE / IT	WAS WORKING
you / we / they	were working

when + past simple, while + past continuous.

New this time: two more jobs it does.

1. Two long actions at the same time. Put while in front of one of them:

   While* Lina was building the website, her uncle was working* in the shop.

2. A picture at one moment in the past, often with still:

   At eleven o'clock she was still working.

Quick practice. Put the verb in the past continuous:

1. While Lina _____ (build) the website, her uncle _____ (work) in the shop.
2. At midnight she _____ (still / study).
3. They _____ (wait) for the connection when it came back.

We use the present perfect when the past still touches now: She has built a website — and the website is there today.

3.1 How we make it

have / has + the past participle

PERSON	PRESENT PERFECT
I / you / we / they	have finished
he / she / it	has finished

The past participle of a regular verb is the -ed form you already know. The common irregular ones must be learned:

NOW	PAST PARTICIPLE
be	been
do	done

NOW	PAST PARTICIPLE
see	seen
take	taken
build	built
lose	lost
sell	sold
meet	met
pay	paid
finish	finished (regular)
learn	learned (regular)
decide	decided (regular)

3.2 What we use it for

Experience, at any time in your life: She has never met her teacher.

Something that started in the past and is still true: He has sold the same things for twenty years.

A past action with a result now: She has lost her work many times, so now she saves every few minutes.

With for and since: for + a length of time (for two years), since + a point in time (since March).

3.4 Present perfect or past simple?

PAST SIMPLE — FINISHED TIME	PRESENT PERFECT — UNFINISHED, OR THE RESULT NOW
In March, she built a website.	Since March, the shop has had new customers.
She published it on a free service.	She has not finished the course yet.
It took her eleven days.	He has sold the same things for twenty years.

The rule to remember: if the sentence says when it happened and that time is over (in March, two years ago, yesterday), use the past simple. If it says for, since, yet, already, ever or never, use the present perfect.

3.5 Negative and question

	FORM	EXAMPLE
Negative	have not / has not + participle	He has not learned to use a computer.
Question	Have / Has + person + participle	Has she finished the course?

3.6 Grammar practice

A. Put the verb in the present perfect:

1. Lina _____ (study) at her college for three years.
2. She _____ (never / meet) her teacher.
3. The shop _____ (have) customers from other cities since March.
4. She _____ (not finish) the course yet.
5. He _____ (already / ask) for two new pages.
6. They _____ (never / see) the shop.

B. Past simple or present perfect?

1. In March, she (built / has built) a website.
2. Since March, the shop (had / has had) new customers.
3. She (published / has published) it on a free service.
4. She (did not finish / has not finished) the course yet.
5. Her uncle (sold / has sold) the same things for twenty years.

C. Write for or since:

1. ____ three years
2. ____ March
3. ____ twenty years
4. ____ she was a child

05 · The short forms of have and has

3.3 The short forms of have and has (listen to `05-have-has-forms.mp3`)

In speech, have and has are almost never said in full. They join the word before them and become very short. This is why the present perfect is hard to hear even when it is easy to write.

FULL	SHORT FORM	SOUND
I have	I've	/aɪv/
you have	you've	/juːv/
they have	they've	/ðeɪv/
he has	he's	/hiːz/
she has	she's	/ʃiːz/
it has	it's	/ɪts/
have not	haven't	/ˈhævənt/
has not	hasn't	/ˈhæzənt/

Inside a sentence, a full have or has is also weak and quiet: /həv/ and /həz/, not /hæv/ and /hæz/.

The one that catches everybody

she's is two different words.

YOU HEAR	IT MEANS	HOW YOU KNOW
She's finished the course.	she has finished	a past participle comes after it
She's a student.	she is a student	a noun or an adjective comes after it

The word after she's tells you which one it is. The same is true of he's and it's.

In the audio you hear each pair twice — the full form, then the short one — and then a test: say whether the 's you hear means has or is, and listen to the answer.

06 · Comprehension — TOEFL question types

Part A — Multiple choice

1. (Factual) What has Lina taught herself?

   A. Information technology.
   B. Web design.
   C. Photography.
   D. The passage does not say.

2. (Factual) How long has her uncle sold the same things?

   A. For two years.
   B. For eleven days.
   C. For twenty years.
   D. Since March.

3. (Negative factual) According to the passage, Lina has done all of the following EXCEPT

   A. finished thirty-eight lessons.
   B. built a website for the shop.
   C. met her teacher.
   D. lost her work many times.

4. (Vocabulary in context) The word "published" in the passage is closest in meaning to

   A. printed on paper.
   B. put on the internet.
   C. sold to a customer.
   D. kept in a folder.

5. (Reference) In the sentence, she published it on a free service, the word "it" refers to

   A. the course.
   B. the shop.
   C. the website.
   D. the message.

6. (Inference) It can be inferred from the passage that

   A. Lina's uncle has learned web design from her.
   B. the slow connection has changed the way Lina works.
   C. the shop has closed since March.
   D. Lina will stop the course after thirty-eight lessons.

7. (Sentence insertion) Look at the four letters [A] [B] [C] [D] in the passage. Where would this sentence best fit?

> The whole thing has cost the shop nothing at all.

- A. At [A]
- B. At [B]
- C. At [C]
- D. At [D]

8. (Purpose of a paragraph) Why does the writer mention that Lina downloads a lesson at night?

A. To show that she prefers working at night.
B. To show how she has worked around a slow connection.
C. To explain why she has never met her teacher.
D. To criticise the internet company.

9. (Purpose of the whole passage — NEW) What is the writer's main purpose in the whole passage?

A. To explain how to build a website.
B. To show that small work, repeated over a long time, produces a real result.
C. To advertise a free online course.
D. To describe daily life in Gaza.

Part C — Fill in the blanks

Use these words. There are two extra words you will not need.

> course · connection · website · prices · published · customers · account · online · password

1. It started with a free _____ on the internet.
2. The _____ in her building is slow.
3. In March she built a _____ for her uncle's shop.
4. The site shows four pages, some photographs and the _____.
5. She _____ it on a free service.
6. Since March, the shop has had _____ from three other cities.
7. She has already decided to build an _____ system.

Part D — Summary

Write the story in two sentences only. Use the present perfect once.

> Sentence 1 — what she has done: _____ Sentence 2 — what has changed for the shop: _____

07 · True / false

Part B — True / False

Write T or F. If it is false, write the correct sentence.

1. Lina has finished the whole course. ____
2. She has never met her teacher. ____
3. Her uncle has used a computer for twenty years. ____
4. The website has four pages. ____
5. The customers from other cities have visited the shop. ____
6. Lina paid nothing to publish the website. ____

08 · Speaking

5.1 Speaking (record each answer, 45 seconds)

1. Tell the story of Lina in your own words. Use for, since, already, and never.
2. What have you taught yourself, with no teacher? How long have you done it?
3. What have you not finished yet, and why not?

Useful sentence starters:

I have studied ____ for ____ years.

I have never ____.

I have already ____, but I have not ____ yet.

Since ____, I have ____.

I taught myself ____, because ____.

09 · Writing — Something I Have Done, Step by Step

5.2 Writing — "Something I Have Done, Step by Step" (12–14 sentences)

Model answer (copy the shape, change the words):

> I have studied English for four years. I started at school, and I was not good at it. Three years ago, I began to study alone, because my class was too fast for me. I have used free videos on the internet since then. I have finished more than two hundred short lessons. I have never paid for a course. At first, I understood almost nothing, and I wrote every new word in a small notebook. Now I have four notebooks, and I read the old ones on Fridays. I have not finished yet. I still make mistakes with tenses, and I have never spoken to a person from England. But my teacher has said that my writing has changed this year. It is slow work, and it is the only work that has helped me.

Checklist before you send it:

- [ ] I used the present perfect at least four times.
- [ ] I used the past simple for the things that happened at a finished time.
- [ ] I used for with a length of time and since with a point in time.
- [ ] I used not … yet, already or never at least once.
- [ ] I used at least 5 new words from Session 2.
- [ ] I used at least 2 words from Lesson 2 or Lesson 3.
- [ ] My text has 12–14 sentences.

10 · Review

6.1 Listen again (no text)

1. Name three things Lina has done in the last two years.
2. What has changed for her uncle's shop since March?

6.2 Mini-quiz (12 marks)

1. The past participle of build is _____
2. The past participle of lose is _____
3. The past participle of see is _____
4. We use ____ with a length of time and ____ with a point in time. (for / since) _____
5. The opposite of free is _____
6. The opposite of online is _____
7. A group of pages on the internet is a _____
8. A person who buys something is a _____
9. Write a sentence with never and the present perfect.
10. Write a negative sentence in the present perfect.
11. Write one sentence with publish.
12. Tell the story of the passage in two sentences, from memory.

6.3 Lesson 4 self-report

QUESTION	ANSWER
Minutes studied this week	
Hardest part (listening / reading / vocabulary / grammar / speaking / writing)	
Present-perfect sentences I can now make without thinking	
Words from Lesson 2 I have forgotten	
One thing I want to repeat next week	

11 · Answer key and teacher notes

Listening: L1 — Lina; she has taught herself web design · L2 — for three years · L3 — a website, for her uncle's shop · L4 — no, she has not finished it yet (two lessons are left)

Part A (MCQ): 1-B · 2-C · 3-C · 4-B · 5-C · 6-B · 7-C · 8-B · 9-B

Why 7 is [C]: the sentence is about cost, and it can only follow the paragraph that says the site was published on a free service because the shop has no money. At [B] and [D]** there is no cost in the text near it.

Why 8 is [B]**: downloading at night is an example of working around the slow connection named in the sentence before it. It is not about preference, and the teacher is in a different paragraph.

Why 9 is [B]**: the passage is not instructions, and it is not about Gaza in general. Every part of it — thirty-eight lessons, eleven days, one small shop — builds to Lina's own last line about doing one small thing many times.

Part B (True/False):

1. F — She has finished thirty-eight lessons; two are left.
2. T
3. F — He has not learned to use a computer.
4. T
5. F — They have never seen the shop.
6. T

Part C (Fill in the blanks): 1. course · 2. connection · 3. website · 4. prices · 5. published · 6. customers · 7. account (Extra words: online, password)

2.4 A (Opposites): 1. expensive · 2. offline · 3. hide / keep private · 4. seller / shopkeeper · 5. finish / end

2.4 B (Odd one out): 1. market (the others are parts of the internet) · 2. password (the others belong to a shop) · 3. free (the others are past-simple verbs)

3.6 A (Present perfect): 1. has studied · 2. has never met · 3. has had · 4. has not finished · 5. has already asked · 6. have never seen 3.6 B (Simple or perfect): 1. built · 2. has had · 3. published · 4. has not finished · 5. has sold 3.6 C (for / since): 1. for · 2. since · 3. for · 4. since

Come back to (past continuous): 1. was building, was working · 2. was still studying · 3. were waiting

Mini-quiz: 1. built · 2. lost · 3. seen · 4. for, since · 5. expensive · 6. offline · 7. website · 8. customer · 9–12. teacher judgement

Teacher Notes

What changed from Lesson 3. The passage grew from 320 to 400 words, the present perfect joins the past simple and the past continuous, and an eighth question type — the purpose of the whole passage — closes the set. The pronunciation slot follows the grammar again, as it has since Lesson 2: the three

sounds of -ed, then the weak was and were, now the short forms of have and has. Everything else is deliberately unchanged.

The one real difficulty. Not the form. It is choosing between I did and I have done, and Arabic gives no help: both land on the same past. The test is whether the sentence names a finished time. Drill 3.4 and 3.6 B until in March pulls the past simple and since March pulls the present perfect without thought. Expect I have built it in March for several weeks, and correct it every time.

Why the listening matters more this week. Have and has almost disappear in speech. A student who can write she has finished will still hear she's finished as she's finish, and then lose the tense entirely. That is the reason part 05 exists, and the reason the she's table is on the sheet: the word after the contraction is the only clue, and she has to learn to use it.

Why this story. It is the first passage with no disaster in it. Lessons 1 to 3 were a slow internet, a lost phone and a power cut — real, but if every passage is a loss the course starts teaching helplessness. This one is about a person whose work accumulated, which is also the honest description of what this course asks of her. The vocabulary is the vocabulary of putting your own work in front of other people: publish, account, customer, update.

Success criteria for Lesson 4. The student should be able to:

- answer L1–L4 correctly on the second hearing;
- hear she's finished and say whether it means has or is;
- form the present perfect of ten verbs, including five irregular participles;
- choose correctly between past simple and present perfect in 3.6 B;
- use for and since correctly;
- use 10 of the 14 key words in her own sentence;
- write 12 sentences about her own experience with fewer than 4 tense errors.

If it is too easy: Lesson 5 goes to about 480 words, adds the present perfect continuous (she has been studying),
and the comprehension set gains a second whole-passage question about the writer's attitude. If it is too hard: keep the same passage for a second week, drop question 9, and drill only 3.1 and 3.4.

A note on spaced recall. `03-vocabulary.mp3` ends with five Lesson 2 words — backup, folder, drive, explain, remember. Lessons 2 and 3 both recalled Lesson 1, so Lesson 2's words have waited two lessons, which is exactly the gap this course keeps. Lesson 3's words are due back in Lesson 5.